

CoARA Action Plan

UHH and CoARA

The University of Hamburg (UHH) agrees with the global academic community that ensuring high-quality and impactful research requires ongoing evaluation and improvement of the criteria, tools, and processes used for assessing research. For this reason, the University has been closely monitoring the European initiative for reforming research assessment from the very beginning.

In March 2023, the University's executive board signed the [Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment](#) (ARRA) in consensus with the Academic Senate which is the central body of academic self-government that includes researchers from various disciplines and career stages. In November of the same year, UHH became a member of the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) being one of the first major German universities to join the Coalition.

Due to the alignment of objectives, we regard our commitment to CoARA as an enhanced contribution to the implementation of Guideline 5 of the "[Guidelines for Safeguarding Good Research Practice](#)" to which we abide as a member organization of the German Research Foundation (DFG).

Our approach

This action plan outlines measures taken by the University of Hamburg to further align our processes of research assessment with the core commitments specified in the ARRA.

The principle that developments and activities in research and research-driven studies and teaching are evaluated primarily on the principle of quality rather than quantitative metrics is firmly anchored in UHH's research culture. Peer review serves as the cornerstone of our research assessment processes. We also adhere to the principle that creating the best conditions for training the next generations of researchers is one of the core responsibilities of the University. These principles are currently being further strengthened through a variety of initiatives in different strategic areas. The individual initiatives can be categorized into two sections.

- *Section 1: Support and career development of early career researchers*
- *Section 2: Development of a future-orientated information system (3i-strategy)*

Our aim is to link these sections **bidirectionally** with CoARA, so that impulses from the community can be adopted and our good practices can be shared with the Coalition.

Therefore, we will participate in the CoARA Working Groups

- *Towards Open Infrastructures for Responsible Research Assessment*
- *Reforming Academic Career Assessment*
- *Early-and-mid-Career Researchers (EMCRs) – Assessment and Research Culture*
- *Ethics and Research Integrity Policy in Responsible Research Assessment for Data and Artificial Intelligence (ERIP)*

Furthermore, we exchange our experiences with German CoARA members as part of the **CoARA National Chapter Germany** and the **CoARA General Assembly** and gather feedback from the community on our reform efforts.

By advancing the reform of research assessment through different sections, the reform process at UHH will progress **incrementally**, driven by a growing **internal network** of stakeholders and disseminators.

The following overview lists actions from the two sections:

Action	Explanation
Support and career development of early career researchers	
Hub of Career and Research Culture	The University is committed to fostering a career and research culture that promotes critical reflection, a pursuit of knowledge, diversity of opinion, academic freedom, and transparent career paths, that are responding to individual developments. We aim to create a research and career environment that emphasizes participation, appreciation, and recognition, setting national and international standards. To achieve this, we will connect all relevant internal stakeholders in an innovative Hub of Career & Research Culture, which will serve as a platform to support and monitor the implementation of strategic initiatives, such as the Hamburg Declaration on University Careers in Academia . A first major milestone will be an Open Forum on Career & Research Culture and a subsequent workshop for research and administrative staff in November 2024. This will be followed by the formal implementation of the hub in early 2025.
Creating new attractive career paths in research	As part of its commitment to the "Hamburg Declaration," UHH is developing new career paths towards permanent professorship, flanked by innovative novel career paths alongside the professorship. A major milestone will be the implementation of the positions of (Senior) Researcher and

	(Senior) Lecturer at University of Hamburg in the winter semester 2024/25.
Reforming the Ideas and Venture Fund	The Ideas and Venture Fund (IVF) provides fast and uncomplicated institutional start-up funding for researchers at UHH who are planning preliminary studies, project preparation workshops or networking activities as preparatory work for acquiring third-party funding. In 2024, funding was directed exclusively at ECRs for the first time. The assessment process is based on a peer review procedure in which ECRs who have already been successful in the IVF's target formats (e.g. ERC Starting Grant, Emmy Noether Programme, BMBF Junior Research Group Leaders, etc.) evaluate the applications and by doing that gain and deepen their own experience in research assessment. To be optimally prepared for this new role, the reviewers receive workshops on how to work in a review panel in advance.
Training for the reviewers	To ensure a quality-assured selection process in the IVF call, the ECRs on the review panel are trained in peer review techniques by a professional trainer in advance, a programme that has also been successful in our Clusters of Excellence. Based on very positive feedback, the programme is now being further developed and offers ECRs an excellent opportunity to acquire important research assessment skills at a very early career stage, which, in addition to the experience gains, can also have a positive influence on the evaluation of their own research.
Development of a future-orientated information system	
Renewing the system for information supply, provision, and processing (3i-strategy)	With the intention of contributing to the quality assurance of scientific work through open access to research results and an efficient knowledge and data exchange, the transparent and responsible use of research information forms the sustainable basis for responsible research assessment. The university is contributing to this goal in three fields of action: Centre for Sustainable Research Data Management (RDM): The FDM supports scientists in the selection and use of

	digital tools and services in the field of research data and thus creates a sustainable data culture that acts as an incentive to engage with the responsible handling of digital research data and results. By offering skills development at all career levels and in all disciplines, this is sustainably integrated into the university. Research Information System (RIS): The use of our Research Information System (RIS) supports the transparent handling of research data and results and supports the visualization and recognition of the diverse activities associated with research Information supply, provision, and processing (3i): The aim is to develop the task areas of the 3i system in accordance with the future requirements of volatile development and to ensure that the system is capable of constant change. The 3i system - enables user-centred, intuitive and low-barrier support of processes in science - creates AI-enabling co-creation spaces as places for the exchange of information and knowledge in the processes of research, teaching, study and transfer - makes a central contribution to enabling the assumption of responsibility for results and verifiability in science
--	---

As part of its reform efforts, UHH will **enhance the organization's knowledge** about which publication-based metrics are specifically established in the individual disciplines and what significance they hold in RA.

If needed, measures will be taken to raise awareness of irresponsible use of metric indicators.

This initial action plan was presented to the deans of the faculties and was approved by the University's executive board in November 2024

The document will be updated on a regular basis.

Contact us

Prof. Dr. Tilo Böhmann
Vice President of UHH
Tel: +49 40 42838-4476
Email: vp3@uni-hamburg.de